

Dr. Kamil Bernaerts

POST-DOCTORAL RESEARCHER IN POLITICAL SCIENCE

Summary

I am an ambitious, critical and collaborative post-doctoral researcher specializing in the relationship between (affective) polarisation and democracy, with broad interest in all forms of political polarisation and conflict. My research examines both how affective polarisation is (not) linked to democratic attitudes, and how democratic institutions shape polarisation dynamics and their consequences for democratic societies. In my dissertation, I combined a theoretical advancement of the concept of polarisation with extensive empirical analysis. As a winner of the prestigious Frank Cass Prize 2023 for best article in *Democratization*, my published work spans polarisation, conflict, institutional design, deliberative democracy, and political violence.

Positions

2025-2027	Guest professor (10%) UHasselt <i>Course: Introduction to Political Science and Governance (SSW)</i>
2025-2026	Post-doctoral researcher Vrije Universiteit Brussel <i>Program: Evaluating Democratic Governance in Europe (EDGE)</i>
2021-2025	PhD candidate Vrije Universiteit Brussel & University of Warwick

Education

2021-2025	PhD in Political Science Vrije Universiteit Brussel & University of Warwick <i>Successful public defence held at VUB on September 15, 2025</i> Dissertation title: "Friends or Foes: Does polarisation really undermine democracy? Understanding the two-way relationship between polarisation dynamics and the processes and institutions of democratic contestation." <i>Supervisors: Didier Caluwaerts (VUB) & Michael Saward (Warwick)</i>
2020-2021	Master of Science in Political Sciences: European and International Governance Vrije Universiteit Brussel <i>Graduated Summa Cum Laude</i>
2017-2020	BSc in Social Sciences Vrije Universiteit Brussel & Universiteit Gent Minor Political Science <i>Graduated Magna Cum Laude</i>

Prizes and awards

I have been awarded the Excellence Award by the Faculty for being the top student in my master's program. Then, I have been awarded an EUTOPIA PhD scholarship to fund my PhD research. In 2024, I have been awarded the Frank Cass Prize for best article featuring in the journal Democratization in 2023.

March 2024	Frank Cass Prize for Best Article of 2023 Democratization, journal
June 2021	EUTOPIA Co-tutelle Scholarship for joint PhD Program EUTOPIA university alliance
June 2021	Excellence Award Faculty of Economy and Social Sciences, Vrije Universiteit Brussel

Publications

This overview only includes published or accepted articles, datasets and books.

2026	Bernaerts, K. (2026). Affect or emotions? Disaggregating affective polarisation to explain support for liberal democracy in Belgium and the United Kingdom. <i>Political Studies Review</i> (Online First). Bernaerts, K. (2026). PhD Summary: Friends or Foes, Does Polarisation Really Undermine Democracy? Understanding the Two-Way Relationship Between Polarisation Dynamics and the Processes and Institutions of Democratic Contestation. <i>Politics of the Low Countries</i>, 8(1). Bernaerts, K.; Caluwaerts, D. (2026) State of the Unions: survey experiment on various forms of polarisation and democratic consequences in Belgium and the UK. <i>VUB Institutional Data Repository</i>.
2025	Bernaerts, K.; Caluwaerts, D. (2025) Fight or unite? Exploring the link between consensus institutions, polarization and political violence in 113 democracies over time (1900-2023). <i>International Political Science Review</i> (Online First) Bernaerts, K. (2025) Friends or foes: does polarisation really undermine democracy? VUBPRESS Brussels University Press
2023	Bernaerts, K., Blanckaert, B., & Caluwaerts, D. (2023). Institutional design and polarization. Do consensus democracies fare better in fighting polarization than majoritarian democracies? <i>Democratization</i>, 30(2), 153–172. Caluwaerts, D., Bernaerts, K., Kesberg, R., Smets, L. & Spruyt, B., 2023, <i>Frontiers in Political Science</i>. 5(1127372).

Articles in draft

Here I list the articles I am currently working on and/or are under review.

2026	Bernaerts, K., Junius, N. (2026) Polarising alone? The relationship between social contact and affective polarisation in Belgium and the UK (under review at <i>Acta Politica</i>)
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Bernaerts, K., (2026) Rethinking polarisation: how its conflictual origins explain a contested relation with democracy (under review at *Politics of the Low Countries*)

Bernaerts, K., Kavadias, L. (2026) Smarty-pants vs Simpletons? Exploring affective polarisation between education-based groups (working paper)

Bernaerts, K. (2026) Hate, not dislike. A refinement of the relationship between affective polarisation and anti-democratic attitudes. (under review)

2023 **Bernaerts, K.,** Matthieu, J., Junius, N. & Caluwaerts, D. (2023). Beyond the culture wars? Assessing the socio-economic determinants of affective polarization (working paper)

Teaching experience

In this (2025-2026) and the next academic year (2026-2027), I temporarily fill in as guest-professor at the UHasselt to teach an introductory course in political science. Before, I have given guest lectures on polarisation and statistics, and supervised multiple bachelor and master theses.

2025-2027	Guest-professor UHasselt (10%) Course: Introduction to Political Science and Governance Program: Bachelor's in social sciences (UHasselt)
2025-2026	Bachelor thesis workshop: polarisation and democracy Supervision of 3 bachelor theses Program: Bachelor's in political science (VUB) Prof. Dr. Didier Caluwaerts & Prof. Dr. Dimokritos Kavadias
2025-2026	Guest lecture: polarisation and democracy, a complicated relationship Course: Democratic Theory and Practice Program: Bachelor's in Social Sciences (VUB) Prof. Dr. Eline Severs
2024-2025	Bachelor thesis workshop: polarisation and democracy Supervision of 4 bachelor theses Program: Bachelor's in political science (VUB) Prof. Dr. Silvia Erzeel
2023-2024	Bachelor thesis workshop: polarisation and democracy Supervision of 5 bachelor theses Program: Bachelor's in political science (VUB) Prof. Dr. Silvia Erzeel
2023-2024	Guest lecture: exploring quantitative research methods Course: Research methodology Program: Master's in political science (VUB) Prof. Dr. Vjosa Musliu
2022-2023	Bachelor thesis workshop: polarisation and democracy Supervision of 5 bachelor theses Program: Bachelor's in political science (VUB) Prof. Dr. Dimokritos Kavadias
2022-2023	Guest lecture: polarisation and democracy Course: Challenges to Democracy

Presentations

I have presented working papers in 13 international academic conferences or workshops.

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| 2026 | Polarising alone? The relationship between social contact and affective polarisation in Belgium and the UK
Presentation at State of the Federation (Antwerp) |
| 2025 | Friends or Foes: Does polarisation really undermine democracy? Understanding the two-way relationship between polarisation dynamics and the processes and institutions of democratic contestation
PhD defence presentation (VUB) |
| | The Polarisation Paradox? Retheorizing Political Division in Democracy
Presentation at the Political Studies Association Conference (Birmingham) |
| 2024 | "Your liberty ends where mine begins". Which forms of polarisation lead to political intolerance?
Presentation at State of the Federation (Liège) |
| 2023 | "Your liberty ends where mine begins". Which forms of polarisation lead to political intolerance?
Presentation at WVS Conference: (De)polarisation in values, attitudes & beliefs (London) |
| | Polarising alone? Exploring Social Capital's Mitigating Effect on Polarisation
Presentation at International Conference of Europeanists: Europe's past, present and future (Reykjavik) |
| | Fight or Unite? How Satisfaction with Democracy Moderates the Relationship between Affective Polarization and Support for Political Violence
Presentation at International Conference of Europeanists: Europe's past, present and future (Reykjavik) |
| | Divided we fall? How polarization shapes (anti-)democratic process preferences
Presentation at ECPR General Conference (Prague) |
| | Democracy: still the only game in town? Unpacking polarisation's influence on democratic, autocratic and technocratic preferences
Presentation at Politicologenetmaal (Maastricht) |
| | Fight or unite? A global view on how institutions moderate the link between affective polarization and political violence
Presentation at MPSA Conference (Chicago) |
| 2022 | Polarisation: to feel or not to feel?
Presentation at Filolab Polarization and Social Change Summer School (Granada) |
| | Hot or cold? Disentangling the concept of polarisation
Presentation at ECPR General Conference (Innsbruck) |

Navigating the cobweb: toward a conceptual typology of polarisation

Presentation at State of the Politicologenetmaal (Nijmegen)

Fight or unite? How democratic institutions moderate the link between polarization and political violence

Presentation at State of the Federation Conference (Brussels)

Beyond the culture wars? Assessing the socio-economic determinants of affective polarization

Presentation at State of the NORFACE GOVERNANCE Mid-Term Conference (Vienna)

2021

Institutional design and polarisation: do consensus democracies fare better in fighting polarisation?

Presentation at State of the Federation Conference (online)

Professional service

2026-2027

Academic workshop co-organizer

Co-organizing a planned international workshop “The end of affective polarization?” at the Brussels Institute for Advanced Studies (BriAS)

2026

Jury member Daniël Heinsius Prize for best Master Thesis

Organized by the VPW and NKWP

2025

Academic workshop co-organizer

Co-organized international workshop “Polarising Performances or Re-engaging the Audience?” at University of Warwick

2024

Panel chair

World Values Conference on (De)polarisation in values, attitudes & beliefs: comparative perspectives, King’s College London

2022

Panel chair

ECPR General Conference, University of Innsbruck

2022-2025

Peer review

Acta Politica

Social Science Quarterly

Social Inclusion

European Journal of Political Research

European Political Science Review

Nature Human Behaviour

Political Behavior

Community service

2026	Personal blog At my personal website, I write blog articles about my research or matters of interest related to my research for a wider audience. One of these articles was republished by the Hannah Arendt Instituut.
2023- 2026	VUB PACT School Tour For the VUB-organized Pauwels Academy of Critical Thinking (PACT) school tour, I give lectures in secondary schools in Flanders on polarisation and democracy.
2022-2024	Political Science and Sociology Junior Talks Co-organizer of a bridging organisation between the departments of political science and sociology which held weekly seminars where junior researchers could present their work across the disciplines.
2022-2025	Public lectures and debates In my role as researcher connected to the valorisation organisation the Hannah Arendt Institute, I have given 10 presentations to the broader public in schools, public events and public debates. I have built a trusted expert status and am still asked regularly to give debates.
2022-2024	Media occurrences The article “Institutional design and polarization. Do consensus democracies fare better in fighting polarization than majoritarian democracies?” has been featured in Belgian media such as Knack , Het Laatste Nieuws , RTBF and Bruzz .

Languages

Dutch	Native language
English	Proficient

Relevant research skills

Analysis	5 years of experience (self-taught) in R for own research purposes, limited experience in SPSS and Stata
Data-collection	Scripted and fielded my own survey experiment of 2000 respondents in Belgium and the UK for my PhD research project.

References

Didier Caluwaerts	Associate professor, DFUTURE, Vrije Universiteit Brussel didier.caluwaerts@vub.be
Michael Saward	Full professor, PAIS, University of Warwick m.j.saward@warwick.ac.uk
Nino Junius	FWO post-doc fellow, DFUTURE, Vrije Universiteit Brussel nino.junius@vub.be